

E-7 Wedgetail: Political and Reputational Risk

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Executive Summary

The E-7 Wedgetail is currently the most politically exposed programme in Boeing's UK defence portfolio. It has become a recurring case study for MPs and the National Armaments Directorate when making the argument that UK defence procurement is broken, and Boeing has twice been named in evidence sessions as the source of delivery problems rather than the customer as the source of specification problems. That framing is now settled in Westminster's institutional memory: it appears in a 2023 Defence Committee report, a July 2025 Westminster Hall debate, and March 2026 Defence Committee evidence, each repeating the same language.

At the same time, the programme has reached a positive point: the first RAF Wedgetail landed at Lossiemouth in March 2026, and in-service entry is expected within the year. Boeing UK has an opening to change the story before the next natural flashpoint, but that window will not stay open indefinitely.

This report sets out the political timeline, the stakeholders who matter, a probability-weighted forecast of how the next 6–12 months are likely to unfold, and a short set of engagement actions Government Affairs could take now rather than reactively.

Programme and Political Timeline

Date	Event
Mar 2019	UK signs contract for five E-7 Wedgetails to replace the E-3D Sentry, retired without a like-for-like successor.
2021	Integrated Review defence command paper cuts the order from five aircraft to three on cost grounds, while the MoD proceeds with buying all five Northrop Grumman radars regardless.
Jul 2023	Defence Committee report 'It is broke and it's time to fix it' uses Wedgetail as a headline case study, calling the three-aircraft buy 'an absolute folly' and noting the reduced fleet still costs roughly 90% of the original five-aircraft price.
Apr 2025	Public Accounts Committee hearing: acting National Armaments Director Andy Start tells MPs the capability is late and that Boeing has had 'real technical and delivery issues'.
Jul 2025	Westminster Hall debate on the programme, led by the MP for Dumfries and Galloway; the Meriden and Solihull East MP defends the workforce while raising concerns about Boeing's senior management.
Mar 2026	National Armaments Director Rupert Pearce tells the Defence Committee Boeing has been a 'troubled partner', attributing delay to an incorrect assumption that the UK aircraft would closely match the proven Australian build, and to resulting obsolescence and certification issues.
Mar 2026	First RAF E-7 Wedgetail arrives at RAF Lossiemouth
2026 (ongoing)	Initial Operational Capability targeted for later in 2026. The UK's wider Defence Investment Plan, which will set procurement priorities for the next decade, remains delayed.

Stakeholder Map

Stakeholder	Position / Role	Relevance to Boeing
House of Commons Defence Committee	Cross-party scrutiny committee; source of the 'absolute folly' and 'troubled partner' findings	Sets the public narrative other MPs and journalists draw on; next natural hearing point is IOC declaration
Public Accounts Committee	Scrutinises value for money in public spending	Likely venue for a future National Audit Office report on Wedgetail cost overruns
National Armaments Directorate (MoD)	Customer and primary technical authority on the programme	Sets the tone in evidence sessions; Rupert Pearce's language is the most quoted line in current coverage
MP for Meriden and Solihull East	Constituency MP for the Birmingham conversion facility	A natural ally: has already defended the workforce publicly while criticising Boeing's senior management.
APPG on Aerospace	Cross-party group for the wider sector	A lower-risk venue than a select committee to reset the narrative around UK jobs and industrial base
RAF / No. 1 Group, Lossiemouth	End user, now operating the first delivered aircraft	Positive operational stories (training milestones, first exercise) are Boeing's best counter-narrative material

Current Risk Assessment

Two things make this more than a routine procurement gripe. First, the criticism is now repeating across a select committee report, a Westminster Hall debate, and a further committee hearing, which means it has hardened into an accepted framing rather than a one-off news cycle. The language used by MoD witnesses ("troubled partner") is unusually direct for a sitting national armaments director and will be the first quote any journalist reaches for in future coverage. Second, the reduced fleet size means the programme has less operational slack than intended, so any further technical issue or attrition event carries disproportionate reputational weight relative to a five-aircraft fleet.

Forecast (12-month outlook)

The estimates below follow the same calibrated forecasting approach used in my independent Artemis Forecasting work. They use explicit probabilities rather than qualitative hedging, so they can be scored for accuracy after the fact rather than treated as unfalsifiable commentary.

Forecast question	Probability	Horizon
RAF Wedgetail reaches declared Initial Operational Capability	45%	By end of 2026
Programme is raised again in a select committee session (Defence or PAC)	70%	Within 6 months
Defence Investment Plan is published	50%	By end of 2026
Fleet size is revisited (increase from three aircraft)	8%	Within 12 months

Rationale: IOC is held below even odds because the programme has missed every prior internal date since 2021 and MoD's own witness described the delay as ongoing as recently as March 2026. Further committee scrutiny is rated highly likely on base rate alone. Fleet size reversal is rated low because the political and financial cost of admitting the 2021 decision was wrong would fall on a different government than the one that made it, reducing the incentive to revisit it.

Recommended Engagement Actions

Brief lines for the next select committee cycle now, rather than after a hearing is announced. Given the 70% likelihood the programme resurfaces within six months, reactive briefing lines drafted the week of a hearing will read as defensive.

Separate the Meriden and Solihull East relationship from the wider narrative. The MP has already drawn a public distinction between the Birmingham workforce and Boeing's senior management

Use the APPG on Aerospace, not a select committee, as the venue to reintroduce the UK jobs and industrial base story; lower scrutiny, friendlier format, and a natural link to the £879m Apache/Chinook Rotary Wing Enterprise contract signed in April 2026, which supports roughly 1,200 UK jobs and is a strong current story.

Prepare an operational-milestone media plan tied to Lossiemouth so that positive capability stories are ready to place as soon as they are true, rather than assembled after the fact.

Track the Defence Investment Plan publication date closely. Its release is the most likely trigger for the next round of 'what did we get for the money' coverage, and Boeing should have a position ready before it lands rather than responding to it.

Sources

Compiled from House of Commons Library research briefings, Hansard records of Defence Committee and Westminster Hall proceedings, the Defence Committee's 2023 report 'It is broke , and it's time to fix it', and open-source defence trade reporting (Breaking Defense, Shephard Media, Airforce Technology, FlightGlobal, The Defence Post). All facts are drawn from public parliamentary and press sources current as of September 2026; no non-public information is used.